9 Foreign Language Enjoyment and Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety: The Right and Left Feet of the Language Learner

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Introduction

Sometimes it can be difficult to see what has been right in front of us all along, but after it has been pointed out, suddenly it seems obvious. That observation describes how we felt in approaching the topic of language learning enjoyment. It is curious that it has not been named as a prominent concept in the literature on individual differences in SLA. Enjoyment is mentioned frequently by teachers and students alike; as a concept it certainly seems to be relevant to language learning and we suggest that it might just be an important part of the learning and communication process. However, a search across multiple electronic databases for scholarly works with language 'enjoyment' in their title yielded a total of only nine hits, including a mere two research articles in the SLA field. In one of those papers, Green reported that:

> No previous studies known to me have investigated possible relationships between the reported enjoyableness and the perceived effectiveness of different kinds of activities and techniques in order to discover whether students agree with those of us who believe that positive affect and effective teaching do indeed go hand in hand. (Green, 1993: 3)

Green's own results were encouraging – enjoyment and perceived learning effectiveness of the tasks did indeed go hand in hand across 17 activities tested, producing correlations between 0.46 and 0.78, with an impressive average (median) correlation of 0.68. The other research article found also reported little prior work on enjoyment but nonetheless noted that there 'are

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conflicting reports concerning the effects of enjoyment on the L2 process' (Brantmeier, 2005: 496). Indeed, Brantmeier's (2005) own data showed that enjoyment correlated positively with self-assessed ability as measured by a written recall task, but did not correlate significantly with scores on a multiple-choice test.

This state of affairs is reminiscent of the early 1980s, when the topic of language anxiety was not well understood. Teachers, learners and scattered research reports hinted at a potentially important role for anxiety in both language learning and communication, but the research results were mixed and confusing (Scovel, 1978). Development of both the conceptualization of language anxiety and its measurement has produced a much clearer picture of how it affects SLA (Horwitz *et al.*, 1986; MacIntyre & Gardner, 1989). Language anxiety has been linked to a range of sociobiographical and psychological variables (Dewaele, 2002, 2007a, 2007b, 2010, 2013a, 2013b, in press; Dewaele *et al.*, 2008; Dewaele & Shan Ip, 2013; Gregersen, & Horwitz, 2002) and has been described as a strong predictor of success (MacIntyre, 1999). A selective review of the literature (Horwitz, 2010) provides a timeline of 44 papers that consistently show the ways in which language anxiety, identified as a unique form of anxiety that is associated with second-language and foreign-language situations, reliably affects learning and communication. Sorting out conceptual and measurement issues led to productive work on language anxiety, and the same can be done for language enjoyment.

Interest in language enjoyment is part of an emerging trend in the SLA literature to shift focus toward positive emotions and their role as driving forces. MacIntyre and Gregersen (2012: 193), for example, argued that 'positive emotion has a different function from negative emotion; they are not opposite ends of the same spectrum'. Drawing on the broaden-and-build theory of emotion (Fredrickson, 2001, 2013), MacIntyre and Gregersen (2012) argue that a learner's imagination has a positive broadening power, leading to better learning outcomes and the building of resources (e.g. social support, personal confidence). Although there has been considerable prior interest in related issues, such as motivation, learner autonomy and humanistic teaching techniques, the conceptualization of positive emotion in SLA has lagged behind theoretical developments in other areas (see MacIntyre & Mercer, 2014).

With the emergence of positive psychology as a defined specialization, and with the broaden-and-build theory as a framework for understanding positive emotion, we propose that the time is right to closely examine enjoyment in foreign-language learning contexts. Perhaps the best way to explain the concept is to contrast it with a similar experience: pleasure. Csikszentmihalyi (2004) considers enjoyment to be separate from pleasure. Whereas enjoyment can be defined as a complex emotion, capturing interacting dimensions of challenge and perceived ability that reflect the human drive for success in the face of difficult tasks, pleasure is considered simply

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an agreeable feeling. On the one hand, enjoyments occur when people not only meet their needs, but exceed them to accomplish something new or even unexpected; on the other hand, pleasure is a simpler feeling that something likable is happening. To use an analogy from sports, it might be *pleasurable* to win a game by a wide margin but it is not necessarily a game anyone enjoys; alternatively, it is *enjoyable* to play well in a closely contested match where success might mean playing well and either winning or losing the game. Losing a game is not pleasurable but can be enjoyable if one has performed better than expected against a superior opponent. Enjoyment follows personal investment and requires having a stake in an outcome that matters to the person, something that is a self-relevant outcome. Because the stakes can be high, tasks that present an opportunity for enjoyment may also bring risk or anxiety. Csikszentmihalyi (1997, 2004, 2008) describes enjoyment as a key component of flow experiences. Flow is characterized as a 'sweet-spot' in optimally challenging activities, where one is neither feeling overwhelmed nor under-challenged. When completely absorbed in tasks set at optimal levels of challenge – not too easy and not too difficult – one can lose track of time and even lose the sense of self. Flow experiences have not been widely studied in foreign language (FL) education (see Egbert, 2004; see also Chapter 8 of the present volume).

The present chapter provides an in-depth analysis of research initially reported by Dewaele and MacIntyre (2014), who found that learners appear to experience more foreign language enjoyment (FLE) than foreign language classroom anxiety (FLCA), and there is a modest, negative correlation between the two concepts. Further, Dewaele and MacIntyre found that:

> participants who [had] already mastered several languages, who had reached a higher level in the FL, who felt more proficient than their peers, who had reached [a] higher level of education and who were older reported significantly more FLE and significantly lower levels of FLCA. In addition, those studying more FLs also scored significantly higher on FLE, where[as] FLCA was not associated with studying more FLs. (Dewaele & MacIntyre, 2014: 262)

Women experienced both higher FLE and higher FLCA. In addition, broad regional differences also were reported, with North Americans showing the highest scores on FLE accompanied by the lowest scores on FLCA; data from Asian respondents showed the opposite pattern. The large data-set, with over 1700 learners from around the world sampled by internet survey, will be examined in greater detail in the present chapter, which examines the relationship between enjoyment and anxiety, with a focus on the factorial structure of FLE and its conceptual development. Using qualitative data we will support the emerging concept of FLE with excerpts from respondents' accounts of their most enjoyable language learning experiences.

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Research Questions

(1) What are the dimensions underlying FLCA and FLE, and specifically do anxiety and enjoyment items form two separate dimensions?
(2) How do learners describe the elements that are conducive to episodes of enjoyment of the FL?

Method

Participants

A total of 1742 multilinguals (1287 females, 449 males[1]) filled out the study questionnaire, described in the next section. While participants were, overall, relatively young (mean age 24 years, SD 8.5 years), their age range was wide, spanning 11 to 75 years. The sample had attained various levels of education, but overall was a well educated group (83% had a bachelor's or master's degree). A majority (76%) of the sample was studying one FL. Asked about how they would describe their mastery of the FL in general, a substantial proportion self-reported as high intermediate (41.7%) or advanced (28.2%), 0.5% reported to be beginners, 23.3% low intermediate and 6.4% intermediate.[2] Asked about their relative standing in the FL class, most considered themselves as average (44.2%) or above average (36.5%) learners, relative to their classmates; smaller proportions reported being at the extreme ends of the scale, with 2.4% reporting to be far below average and 6.7% to be far above average, with the remaining 9.8% reporting to be below average.

Close to half of the participants reported that they studied English as a FL ($n = 855$; 49%), followed by French ($n = 276$; 15.8%), Spanish ($n = 218$; 12.5%), Dutch ($n = 157$; 9.0%) and German ($n = 139$; 8.0%).

The participants reported 90 different nationalities, including many participants with double nationalities. The largest groups were Belgians ($n = 365$), followed by British ($n = 244$), Chinese ($n = 174$) and Americans ($n = 118$), along with many smaller groups ($n < 80$). Broad regional groups were created: the largest group consisted of Europeans ($n = 1171$; 67.1%), followed by Asians ($n = 229$; 13.1%), North Americans ($n = 149$; 8.5%), South Americans ($n = 92$; 5.3%) and Arabs ($n = 87$; 5.0%). The sample consisted of 456 bilinguals (26.1%), 555 trilinguals (31.8%), 415 quadrilinguals (23.8%), 202 pentalinguals (11.6%) and 70 sextalinguals (4%). The 44 remaining participants (2.5%) reported knowledge of 7 to 10 languages. A single category was created that included all participants with six or more languages. More details on the sample can be found in Dewaele and MacIntyre (2014).

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The instrument

The questionnaire started with a sociodemographic section that generated the data reported immediately above. Next, participants were asked to indicate to what extent they agreed with 29 items describing the FL class, of which 8 were extracted from the FLCA scale devised by Horwitz *et al*. (1986) and the rest were FLE items (see the Appendix to this chapter). Responses were recorded on a standard 5-point Likert scale (strongly disagree = 1, disagree = 2, neither agree nor disagree = 3, agree = 4, strongly agree = 5). All items referring to FLE were positively phrased. Six of the eight FLCA items were phrased to indicate anxiety, while the other two items were phrased to indicate comfort (these items were recoded when computing total scores for the scale).

The final (open) item was: 'Describe one specific event or episode in your FL class that you really enjoyed, and describe your feeling in as much detail as possible'.

The questionnaire was pilot-tested with 15 participants. This led to the deletion of some items and the reformulation of others. The research design and questionnaire obtained approval from the Ethics Committee of the School of Social Sciences, History and Philosophy at Birkbeck College, University of London. The final version of the questionnaire was put online using Googleforms and an open call was addressed to multilinguals, including those who had participated in previous studies, asking them to forward the call to friends, teachers or students.

Data analysis

Our approach to data analysis can be described as the data-validation variant of a convergent parallel design (Cresswell & Plano Clark, 2011). In this design, both quantitative and qualitative data are collected at the same time, making it an efficient research design, especially for large samples. The purpose of the quantitative data in this approach is to identify the major dimensions underlying the items that measure FLCA and FLE. The purpose of the qualitative data is to provide examples of the statistical dimensions, written by learners themselves. Results provided by the two types of data are mixed and combined in the Discussion section below. One concern about this type of analytic approach is that

> [b]ecause the qualitative items are an add-on to a quantitative instrument, the items generally do not result in a complete context-based qualitative data set. However, they provide the researcher with emergent themes and interesting quotes that can be used to validate and embellish the quantitative survey findings. (Cresswell & Plano Clark, 2011: 81)

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The analysis proceeded in two stages. In the first, an exploratory factor analysis, using a principal components analysis (PCA) with Varimax rotation, was used to determine which of the 29 items clustered together to form general factors. In the second stage, we examined the responses to the open-ended item that asked for examples of an enjoyable episode. The choice of data extracts reported below was guided by the principle that they had to be representative of the category, poignant, concise and interesting. In this way, we give a voice to participants, allowing us to add an emic dimension to the abstract, etic statistical dimensions.

Results

Assessing factor structure

The first step in the analysis examined whether the data met the assumptions underlying factor analysis. Cases with missing values were excluded list-wise. Bartlett's test of sphericity ($\chi^2 = 18{,}829$, d.f. $= 406$, $p < 0.0001$) and the Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin measure of sampling adequacy (KMO $= 0.91$) exceeded the recommended value of 0.6 (Kaiser, 1970). Thus, both suggested that factor analysis of the data was possible.

The second step involved examining the factor structure and naming the factors. Factors will be named by considering items that load above ± 0.50 on each of the factors. The number of factors to retain was determined by examining the scree plot of eigenvalues, testing various solutions, and choosing the most theoretically meaningful set of factors. The scree plot suggested four factors but the fourth factor received high loadings (a loading > 0.50) from only three items and generated cross-loadings with other factors – both are signs of over-factoring. Therefore, a three-factor solution was retained and rotated with both Varimax and Direct Oblimin criteria. The Varimax rotation sets the correlation between factors at zero (0) and produces results that reflect a simple structure in which items tend to load on only one factor. The Direct Oblimin rotation allows for correlations among the factors and it produces somewhat more complex solutions, including the need to interpret the correlations among factors and a stronger tendency for items to load on more than one factor. Although we present both solutions below, our emphasis will be on the simpler structure of the Varimax rotation.

The three-factor solution was tested using a principal components analysis of the covariance matrix. After rotation, the extracted factors accounted for 44.8% of the variance in the covariance matrix (see Table 9.1). The first factor explains 25.9% of the variance. After rescaling, Factor I obtained high positive loadings (> 0.50) from the eight items taken from the FLCA scale; all of the items worded to reflect high anxiety showed positive

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Table 9.1 Result of the principal components analysis

Item	*Factor I*	*Factor II*	*Factor III*
Heart pounding	0.76	−0.13	0.09
Start to panic	0.76	−0.02	−0.07
Nervous and confused	0.74	−0.02	−0.19
Feel anxious	0.71	−0.02	−0.14
Other students speak better	0.70	0.02	−0.18
Confident speaker	−0.65	0.05	0.33
Embarrassed to volunteer	0.62	−0.10	−0.16
Don't worry about mistakes	−0.61	0.24	−0.03
Laugh off embarrassing mistakes	−0.30	0.29	−0.06
Laugh a lot	−0.06	0.77	0.19
Tight group	−0.04	0.76	0.06
Common 'legends'	0.00	0.73	0.01
Good atmosphere	−0.12	0.64	0.37
Teacher is supportive	−0.04	0.57	0.43
Teacher is friendly	−0.05	0.56	0.39
Teacher is encouraging	−0.05	0.56	0.43
Peers are nice	−0.14	0.54	0.18
Positive environment	−0.18	0.50	0.43
Enjoy it	−0.16	0.21	0.70
It's fun	−0.18	0.26	0.62
Don't get bored	−0.02	0.21	0.61
Learnt interesting things	−0.03	0.22	0.58
Feel proud	−0.14	0.17	0.52
Express myself better	−0.15	0.02	0.49
Cool to know a FL	−0.06	0.10	0.42
Worthy member of the class	−0.34	0.10	0.41
Different person during class	0.19	−0.03	0.37
Can be creative	−0.24	0.07	0.31
Making errors is part of learning	−0.19	0.25	0.29

factor loadings with Factor I and both of the reverse-coded items showed negative factor loadings (see Table 9.1). This factor clearly reflects *Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety*.

The second factor accounts for 13.0% of the variance and received loadings > 0.50 from eight items – those with keywords *laugh a lot, form a tight group, have common 'legends' (such as running jokes), a good atmosphere, teacher is supportive, friendly* and *encouraging, peers are nice* and *there is a positive environment.* All of the items on Factor II appear to reflect characteristics of

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Table 9.2 The oblique rotation from the three-factor solution

Item	*Factor I*	*Factor II*	*Factor III*
Nervous and confused	**-0.76**	-0.15	-0.24
Start to panic	**-0.76**	-0.13	-0.12
Heart pounding	**-0.75**	-0.20	0.02
Feel anxious	**-0.72**	-0.13	-0.18
Other students speak better	**-0.72**	-0.10	-0.23
Confident speaker	**0.69**	0.20	**0.38**
Embarrassed to volunteer	**-0.65**	-0.20	-0.22
Don't worry about mistakes	**0.62**	**0.30**	0.04
Laugh off embarrassing mistakes	**0.32**	**0.30**	-0.00
Laugh a lot	0.17	**0.80**	0.30
Tight group	0.13	**0.75**	0.16
Common 'legends'	0.08	**0.71**	0.11
Good atmosphere	0.23	**0.71**	**0.46**
Teacher is supportive	0.16	**0.64**	**0.50**
Teacher is encouraging	0.16	**0.63**	**0.51**
Teacher is friendly	0.16	**0.63**	**0.47**
Positive environment	0.29	**0.59**	**0.50**
Peers nice	0.22	**0.58**	0.26
Enjoy it	0.27	**0.36**	**0.73**
It's fun	0.28	**0.40**	**0.66**
Don't get bored	0.12	**0.33**	**0.63**
Learnt interesting things	0.12	**0.33**	**0.61**
Feel proud	0.22	0.28	**0.54**
Express myself better	0.21	0.14	**0.50**
Worthy member of the class	**0.39**	0.22	**0.44**
Cool to know a FL	0.13	0.19	**0.43**
Different person during class	-0.15	0.02	**0.35**
Making errors is part of learning	0.25	0.33	**0.34**
Can be creative	0.28	0.16	0.34

Table 9.3 Correlation of Factors I–III

	I	*II*	*III*
I	1.00	0.25	0.20
II	0.25	1.00	0.34
III	0.20	0.34	1.00

Extraction method: principal component analysis.
Rotation method: Oblimin with Kaiser normalization.

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the social setting or the presence of other people; therefore, the factor will be named *Foreign Language Enjoyment–Social.*

The third factor explained an additional 5.9% of the variance. It obtained high positive loadings from five items (*I enjoy it*, *it's fun*, *don't get bored*, *learnt interesting things* and *feel proud*). All of the items on Factor III appear to capture the personal reactions to learning that reflect relatively inner thoughts and feelings and therefore the factor will be named *Foreign Language Enjoyment–Private.* Factor III also produced smaller, noteworthy loadings (> 0.30) from nine other enjoyment items, suggesting a considerable degree of overlap between Factors II and III.

In Table 9.2, we present the oblique solution produced by Direct Oblimin rotation. The interpretation of the three factors is much the same and we would not choose to relabel them based on this alternative rotated factor solution. If anything, the oblique rotation emphasizes that the two enjoyment factors overlap to a greater extent than the Varimax rotation shows. For example, Table 9.3 shows that Factors II and III correlate at a modest $r = 0.34$. Furthermore, if we use the loading > 0.30 criterion, the number of cross-loadings increases dramatically. It should be noted also that both FLE–Social and FLE–Private correlate significantly with FCLA ($r = –0.25$ and $r = –0.20$ respectively). The oblique rotation does not separate the factors as cleanly as the Varimax rotation did; taken together, the results emphasize that these three factors are related to each other.

Selection of participants' views on enjoyable episodes in the FL class

One of the advantages of a mixed methods study such as this one is that the quantitative results can be reflected in learners' descriptions of experience, each enriching the interpretation of the other. In the present case, we focus on the two FLE factors (Social and Private) that emerged from the quantitative analyses. These factors show connections to the categories 'Peer recognition' and 'Teacher recognition' (146 and 116 comments respectively) for FLE–Social and to the categories 'Individual realization of progress' as well as 'Authentic use of the FL' for FLE–Private (108 and 26 comments respectively), as reported by Dewaele and MacIntyre (2014). The excerpts taken from the learners' responses are used below to help clarify the nature of the factors and to begin to link enjoyment to other aspects of the learners' experiences. If the factor analysis works to pull apart the concept of enjoyment by isolating principal components of the experience, the qualitative analysis below helps to put those components back together, as learners experience them *in situ*.

Close to two-thirds of participants ($n = 1076$) answered the open question, producing a total of 52,471 words. The average length of the feedback was only 48.8 words; that is, participants gave brief descriptions

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of enjoyable events. Even though the descriptions are brief, it was at times difficult to identify excerpts as indicative of only one of the factors, and we recognize that other interpretations can be made. In the following qualitative analysis, we will identify what we see as the most salient features of the excerpts as a way to further develop the conceptualization of FLE and its components. A fuller contextualization of FLE would require additional data collection.

FLCA

The first factor reported above is defined by the combination of social apprehension, worry and physical manifestations of anxiety in the language classroom. The open-ended question did not enquire about this dimension directly, and only 37 participants alluded to it. Participants (who are here and below denoted by two-letter codes, and are quoted verbatim and uncorrected) in the following three excerpts linked their FLCA to the obligation of using the FL with their usual teacher, their anxiety about fear of ridicule in front of peers, and the experience of using of the FL in real-life communication, which helped them overcome their anxiety.

> **ST** (female, 15): We had a cover teacher so I knew we would not have to speak French, relieved and no longer anxious, I could relax.

> **CC** (female, 21): [With this specific activity] not only [you] have more communication with your classmates, and you can say what you think. Don't have to worry about you will laugh at me, when I couldn't express yourself in English, the students will help me.

> **LA** (female, 20): I have been abroad for one year (to England and Spain). There I've spoken very little French (my L1). I was speaking in English or in Spanish whenever I had the opportunity to. It made myself much more confident (worrying less about people's reaction, putting things into perspective, accepting not to be always as accurate as I wish in what I am saying…) as far as now I am much more talkative when I speak English.

Some people are worriers by nature. MI reports in the following extract how she experienced FLCA both before and immediately after an oral presentation in the FL, and how happy she felt with the praise from the teacher.

> **MI** (female, 19): I had to prepare an oral group presentation, which lasted 10 minutes. The topic we were going to talk about wasn't very complicated. Still I got nervous before doing it. When we finished our presentation, I realized I'd forgotten something to say, but I didn't think it could affect [the] presentation. The teacher said to me that my

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pronunciation and delivery of the work was very satisfactory. At that moment, I felt quite proud of myself. I'm usually told that my English is quite good, however, I'm not a very confident person.

These comments reflect the moderate negative relationship between FLCA and FLE (Dewaele & MacIntyre, 2014). Indeed, some participants linked the absence of FLCA to an increased enjoyment of the class ('I can relax', 'nobody will laugh at me'). Participant LA took a long-term perspective, explaining how the experience of being a FL user rather than just a FL learner had reconciled her with the fact that FL users do not need to be perfect in order to function effectively in the target language (cf. Dewaele, in press; Gregersen & Horwitz, 2002), which had lowered her FLCA and boosted her self-confidence and willingness to communicate in the FL. The above excerpt showed that FLCA did not stop MI from feeling proud of her performance.

FLE–Social

The second factor, FLE–Social, is defined by positive feelings, encouraging peers, nice teachers, and a supportive environment. A good atmosphere among teacher and peers seems to be a crucial element in producing enjoyment. The following three excerpts highlight the social dimensions of FLE–Social.

XZ (female, 42): The atmosphere is great and all members feel comfortable speaking Italian. What's more, we laugh a lot which is in my opinion very important when learning a language!

TX (female, 45): If everyone is happy in class it gives the extra boost to learn better and improve even though I make many mistakes both in spoken and written language. I also learned from my classmates a lot because since the beginning of the FL classes there [*sic*] were there with me and it is encouraging to see the familiar people you have studied with again. That gave me a sigh of relief and we are together again in the third year with different teachers of course!

DX (male, 20): I was telling my fellow students about my 3 month stay in Cuba and I noticed that they really enjoyed listening to what I have experienced, so I kept talking and I felt quite proud of how fluent I can tell a story. I felt confident and enjoyed 'showing off' my own skills.

In all three excerpts above, the social life of the classroom clearly comes into focus as learners engage in meaningful ways with their peers and teachers – people are laughing and enjoying each other's contributions to the group. In these excerpts, we see a cascading process of enjoyment,

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and evidence for the long-term relationship development referenced in the broaden-and-build theory (Fredrickson, 2001, 2013). Enjoyment ripples outward from the speaker and returns back to her or him in a self-reinforcing cycle that is a mirror image of the self-exacerbating nature of anxiety. Using Fredrickson's terminology, the sense of being familiar and comfortable in the language group is a part of the process of building resources for the future, a form of social capital upon which students can draw when times are tough (see Chapter 6 of this volume).

> **XL** (male, 18): During the Dutch lesson, a few weeks ago, we had to make groups and talk about photos, describe them as much as possible. I really enjoyed it because the atmosphere was great and we all felt like a group of friends working in a pleasant way on our photos. It helped everyone being confident about the FL, even though some people needed more time to talk (they were helped by everybody then).

Social support among peers, as mentioned at the end of XL's excerpt above, seems to be quite natural when a group has shared enjoyment. Given that language learners often must step outside their comfort zone, the facilitating effects of enjoyment can be powerful, as DD explains:

> **DD** (female, 19): When we had to perform something in my English FL class to practise our intonation and such, I chose a piece from my favourite show. It was a speech that has to be performed with a lot of energy and in a loud voice (which is something completely different than my usual self). But when I had said the first sentence, I felt relaxed and at ease. I enjoyed it so much that I wished the speech was longer so that I would be able to continue talking. I felt almost euphoric. That was the moment in which I realized how much my class had helped me to advance in talking English in front of an audience.

At the heart of the issue seemed to be a sense of the teacher as a participant in the learning situation. Some participants, such as XF, noticed and appreciated the skills of their teacher in creating a 'buzzing' atmosphere where everybody feels they have learnt something by the end of class:

> **XF** (female, 24): I love having a teacher who knows how to read the room and communicate with the class. Having a skilled teacher makes a huge difference to the answers to these questions, naturally. If I had been answering this a few months ago, with a different teacher, my answers would have been very different. I love it when the teacher can deliver appropriate content to everyone in the class without losing people's attention. I feel like it's been a great class when everyone has been learning, brains have been buzzing, energy is high and you go away feeling like you're further on than you were when you entered the room.

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> **AY** (male, 16): I enjoyed my MFL [modern foreign language] class when the teacher was ill and we had another teacher covering. She was a native speaker and added in to fill our wide gaps in colloquial and slightly less formal, more natural German. I really enjoyed that class because everyone was included and she treated us like equals although our grasp of the language was far from perfect.

In both excerpts above, the students are comparing teachers who create enjoyable classes with unnamed teachers who do not. However, the dividing line between teacher behaviour that is enjoyed versus anxiety-arousing can be razor thin (MacIntyre *et al.*, 2011). A classroom atmosphere that can accommodate teasing and other forms of humour must be handled adeptly, as in the three following instances:

> **MH** (male, 21): When I was preparing an extra oral exercise for my Japanese class, I had to sing a song and the teacher have to evaluate my pronunciation … and when I finished singing the teacher said joking: please take my seat and tell me how to sing in Japanese so well.

> **SM** (female, 36): I was surprised when she thanked me so graciously, with the sensei honorific, and the low bow she gave. I appreciated that it was largely for everyone's amusement, but I enjoyed the gesture, even though I recall wringing my hands nervously, bowing and shaking my head. It was a fun moment for the whole class.

> **MW** (female, 20): I remember a time when the teacher scolded me for helping my class mates and ended up been ordered to go in front of the class to correct the exercise knowing fully that I don't like attention which made me very nervous and saying things as jokes which made the class and teacher laugh and forget about me :)

There are many classroom activities that will be enjoyable for some, but likely not for all learners. Although some teacher-trainers might cringe at the techniques described in the responses of MH, SM and MW above, the learners themselves offered them as their example of enjoyment in the language classroom.

Enjoyment for one might not be enjoyment for all. For example, competition in the form of games or a public debate can place the focus on developing skills in a challenging atmosphere. For some students, this is arousing, motivating and enjoyable.

> **XX** (female, 19): A very positive episode was my freshman year of high school, before the teacher drama, when we played a partner game where one person sat down away from a screen and the other person faced the

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screen and described the word on it in Spanish. The seated partner had to guess the word. I LOVE competition and games really enhance my memory, so I'd like to do things like that again.

RL (female, 23): During one of my speaking classes we were divided into 2 opposite groups. One group was for, the other was against. I can't really remember the topic of the discussion, but it was really challenging. We were supposed to prepare before the class and collect some arguments, data and research. As I remember this class was very fascinating, not only because it was a heated discussion, but also we were very involved in it and very productive; I forgot about the time. And I have an impression that this lesson had a great contribution into my speaking skills.

Teachers would do well to keep in mind one of the key lessons from positive psychology – the individual's unique configuration of traits, strengths and emotions makes it difficult to predict the reaction of individual students to specific exercises (Reschly *et al.*, 2008; Seligman *et al.*, 2005).

Overall, this limited collection of excerpts helps to demonstrate that a positive emotion such as enjoyment can have a significant social component that works both to broaden one's openness to new experiences as well as to build social relationships that serve as resources for the future. The second major dimension might be the one that comes to mind more easily in thinking about enjoyment, that is, the private feeling that accompanies success in the face of difficult tasks.

FLE–Private

The third dimension emerging from the principal components analysis was named the FLE–Private factor. Participants who mentioned experiences of private enjoyment in answer to the open question described the feelings and cognition that accompany enjoyment. Consistent with the definition of enjoyment, thoughts and feelings coalesce around a sense of accomplishment.

NN (male, 22): But I can remember when I was 14 and had French as FL we had to learn poems and be able to recite them to the class and the teacher would score how good we were at it. I can still remember 2 poems of Jacques Prévert even if it's been almost ten years. I remember the feeling of being able to speak full sentences with perfect accents and knowing the meaning of every single word and the sense of the whole thing together would just start to make sense and so would other sentences. I remember after doing my presentation feeling like a native French speaker, like nobody could say I was not able to speak French! I remember feeling happy and excited about it! I was not afraid of speaking or making mistakes.

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MX (female, 21): The exploration of lexical terms and being really engaged in the studying of the origins of words. We were looking at where certain words came from based on their Latin and Greek origins. I was excited to study something different and I was extremely intrigued with the history of words. I wanted to learn more, I craved the knowledge and I didn't ever want to leave the class.

XY (male, 25): The teacher always begins the class with a discussion on a random topic, usually initiated by a story told by one of the students about his/her weekend etc. This spring I had been travelling in Japan with my family and I was telling about the trip and my emotions for around 15–20 minutes. I felt very free and almost forgot I was speaking a foreign language because the topic was very personal and I was so engaged.

Most episodes of enjoyment described by participants related to instances of personal triumph within the group, moments of private pleasure at the realization that they had progressed in the FL. This sense of accomplishment is not divorced from the social dimensions of learning in a group, but the emphasis is on personal success and pride.

EX (female, 20): Being able to answer the really hard questions, gives me a great sense of satisfaction and gratification for the work I've put in. This way you know you are not doing all the exercise for naught.

CL (female, 24): When I nailed the pronunciation on a sentence I read out loud in my seminar group.

Each of these examples presents positive affective states, but the term 'pleasure' does not seem to be strong enough to capture the essence of the experience. Feeling that one is happy and proud, gratified and satisfied, and that one has 'nailed' a difficult task are all consistent with the definition of enjoyment. At times, this feeling can be enhanced by social comparison.

TH (female, 45): When I answered a question no one else in class understood or knew the answer to but I did. I felt happy and proud to know the answer.

The teacher can play a central role in stimulating FLE, but not always in a straightforward way. At times, students seemed to form a group that operated somewhat independently of the teacher.

IP (female, 16): This was not a set exercise by my teacher. Two people next to me decided to not do the set work, choosing instead to speak to

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each other about anything they wanted but it had to be in French. They did very well and whenever they found they were stuck, they picked up a dictionary and solved their problem. As I listened I could tell they became more and more confident and excited about the language and eventually [I] joined in. By the end, they both said they had learnt more in those twenty minutes than they normally would in a week and really enjoyed the feeling of accomplishment, rather than the relief of finishing a boring workbook exercise and knowing you had no homework. It made me wish lessons were more like that all the time.

Discussion

The concept of FLE is proving to be rich and multifaceted. We have reported data analysis elsewhere showing that the FLE and FLCA scales are significantly negatively correlated ($r = -0.36$) and associated with a number of sociobiographical variables (Dewaele & MacIntyre, 2014). In this chapter, we have looked more deeply into the conceptualization and measurement of FLE. Not only did the Varimax rotation of the factor analysis above show that FLCA and FLE could be defined as separate dimensions, we also discovered an interesting, unanticipated differentiation of the social and the private components of the FLE scale. It must be emphasized, however, that although these three factors can be separated, the oblique rotation serves to remind us that there is a noticeable degree of overlap among them.

The qualitative section of the questionnaire invited participants to share a positive experience in their FL class and that provided a treasure trove of information. Excerpts from these open-ended responses allowed us to better understand the texture of enjoyable language learning experiences, but we consciously refrain from drawing firm conclusions from them.

The factor analysis confirms that anxiety forms a factor that is distinct from enjoyment. The concepts do not necessarily operate in a seesaw relationship, where one goes up and the other goes down, but rather they function somewhat independently. One participant, LA, mentioned that after having spent a year abroad, she had finally understood that nobody outside the classroom expects FL users to be perfect. This revelation allowed her to become more confident and more talkative in her FLs. There were interesting examples of FLE and FLCA going hand in hand in the qualitative data, as in MW's excerpt, where she says she said managed to overcome her anxiety and make jokes at the front of the class, relieving her own tension and making her peers and teacher laugh. Being filmed and made to analyse many errors may seem to be a form of cruel punishment to some students, but another of the respondents drew satisfaction from the fact that it allowed her to know that the numbers of errors she made decreased over time. Other

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learners described activities, including those with a competitive edge such as games and debates, that some teachers and students might prefer to avoid for fear of anxiety arousal. Yet, in these cases, positive emotion emerged from a potentially negative situation.

From a pedagogical perspective, these findings reflect many of the observations made by Gregersen and MacIntyre (2014) on ways for FL teachers to reduce FLCA and to boost enjoyment in the FL, or more generally to empower the students by giving them choice in the selection of classroom activities. From a theoretical perspective, these results confirm the importance of Csikszentmihalyi's (2004) distinction between pleasure and enjoyment, highlighting the potential risk inherent in instances of enjoyment. When the focus is on evidence of skill development in the face of challenge, the emotionally ambivalent tone of a classroom can resolve toward the positive and result in the shared experience of enjoyment (see MacIntyre, 2007).

The factor analysis also produced a factor labelled FLE–Social. This factor was composed of items with key words such as *laugh*, *common 'legends'*, a *tight group* with teachers and peers who are *nice*, *encouraging* and *supportive*, *positive environment* and a *good atmosphere*. In the qualitative data, the social side of FLE concept comes into clearer focus. Many students underlined the importance of doing well in front of their peers, and remembered instances where they 'nailed' it, as CL pointed out. Very often these positive events marked a new period in the student's learning curve: there seems to be a 'before' that is left behind as the new skills or mastery has been recognized in front of peers and teacher. Of course, teachers play a crucial part in nurturing the FLE of their students; how they relate with their students is extremely important. Teachers showing respect for the needs and limitations of students was cited many times in the data (not reported here). A teacher's judicious praise on a particular aspect of FL production can do wonders for a learner's feeling of achievement. Teachers being humorous and able to read the atmosphere in the classroom also were mentioned as facilitating enjoyment. It is perhaps the ability of the teacher to read the emotional atmosphere of the classroom, coupled with the characteristics and experiences of the students, that allows potentially risky teaching behaviours to produce enjoyment rather than anxiety in these cases.

Although there is a shared component of enjoyment, results also point to a private side of the concept. Private feelings are captured in phrases associated with Factor III such as *enjoy it*, *learnt interesting things*, *don't get bored*, *feel proud* and *it's fun*. We interpret this factor as indicating an internal sense of enjoyment in the face of challenges. The qualitative data point to instances of an inward pride, as in discussing something deeply personal or meaningful. There can be a sense of enjoying one's success in spite of obstacles presented by teachers or peers, a feeling of success that nobody can take away, as in the case of NN. The qualitative data also provide evidence of enjoyment of some teaching techniques that generally would

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be considered risky, even if done with benevolent intent (as in excerpts from MH, SM and MW). These private states suggest a contrast between past and present that is recognized by the learner as evidence of language development, especially in difficult areas. Future research might investigate whether FLE–Private has significant elements of pride associated with it. As it was defined in Factor III, however, the emphasis would be on the private feeling of enjoyment from accomplishing something that was difficult and in spite of obstacles.

Before concluding, we must note some of the limitations of the present study. Although we have a large sample, there is a tendency for the respondents to be female, well educated, and experienced learners. This may reflect a positive bias, in the sense that participants who are willing to complete an anonymous, voluntary, online survey about language learning may be the ones who especially enjoy language learning. Although we were hoping to gain insight into positive experiences, we cannot claim to have a random or representative sample. The bulk of the respondents came from Europe and the results may not generalize equally well to all areas of the world. In addition, all of the respondents had to have access to a computer in order to complete the web-based survey, and they had to be invited by someone who had heard about the research project. Although the size of the sample allows for advanced multivariate statistics, a large sample also can lead to small relationships being declared statistically significant.

The qualitative analysis also produced its challenges for interpretation. The extracts give only a brief sketch of FLE arising from a unique confluence of internal and contextual factors. Participants referred to their unique context at one specific point in time. They varied in their choice of temporal focus: many described an episode that ranged from a minute to an hour, while some described episodes spread over the academic year. We have pointed out elsewhere that 'longer timescales could be linked to qualitatively different interpretations of enjoyment' (Dewaele & MacIntyre, 2014: 255; see also Chapter 11 of the present volume). The categorization of episodes was also complicated by the fact that some respondents described specific events but others described a pattern of events or their perceptions of their classroom experience rather than the experience itself. Some participants spontaneously mentioned other positive emotions, such as pride and satisfaction, and others referred to negative emotions such as FLCA.

Thematic categorization of verbal data is a messy affair, as many observations touched upon multiple themes and could therefore have been categorized differently. Even brief entries, such as the comment reported above by SM who was thanked by her Japanese teacher with an amusing and exaggerated honorific, can produce multiple themes. Although the dominant theme in her response was identified as teacher skills, there are also elements of teacher and peer recognition, and even a hint of anxiety. The development of the concept of FLE would be facilitated by qualitative

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methods such as in-depth interviewing or focus groups that could provide richer, contextualized detail about enjoyable language learning episodes.

Yet, in spite of (or perhaps because of) the challenges encountered in this project, we are hopeful that future research will further clarify the conceptualization and measurement of FLE. Further quantitative research can explore the correlates, predictors and consequences of the dimensions of FLE. Detailed qualitative analysis is needed to further contextualize enjoyment within learners' experiences. With additional research and the insights it brings, we anticipate that the FLE concept will take its rightful place among variables relating to individual differences known to affect the language learning process.

Conclusion

Foreign Language Enjoyment can be defined as a separate dimension from Foreign Language Classroom Anxiety. Although a modest negative correlation exists between them, they certainly do not overlap completely. We have evidence to support our previous claim that absence of FLCA does not automatically mean that FLE is present (Dewaele & MacIntyre, 2014), although it is possible for FLE to be accompanied by FLCA. The present study also highlighted the fact that there are shades of meaning within FLE. One important dimension is social, in other words, the satisfaction that a learner can draw from a buzzing, positive FL classroom. A second dimension reflects private thoughts and feelings, including the internal pride and satisfaction a learner can experience when something difficult has been achieved. Finally, the positive atmosphere can be created by teachers but also by students, or by a combination of them as the comments revealed: many positive experiences reported by participants involved activities organized by the teacher that gave students a degree of freedom and latitude. These results help to reinforce the understanding that learners are not to be considered as passive recipients of knowledge but as active pursuers of linguistic know-how, authentic communicators in the FL, and valued members of the classroom's speech community.

The learning of a FL takes years and it is hard work. It is not surprising, then, that beginners do not enjoy the FL as much as advanced learners (Dewaele & MacIntyre, 2014). But learners at any level can have a breakthrough moment – it could involve correct pronunciation, a perfect accent in one sentence, making people laugh, or the ability to keep the floor for a long time because of an authentic interest of peers and teachers. As self-confidence grows, FLCA can be controlled as FLE is boosted. Given that the nature of FLE implies risk to the sense of self, the goal is not to eliminate FLCA any more than a runner would wish to eliminate one of her feet

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(even the sore, aching one). Learners will find their balance when both feet, enjoyment and anxiety, are brought into equilibrium. This is not meant to imply equal amounts or a linear process, but a sense of coordination between anxiety and enjoyment.

Appendix. The Questionnaire Items

The FLE scale

To what extent do you agree with the following statements?
[Strongly disagree; Disagree; Undecided; Agree; Strongly agree]

- I can be creative
- I can laugh off embarrassing mistakes in the FL
- I don't get bored
- I enjoy it
- I feel as though I'm a different person during the FL class
- I learnt to express myself better in the FL
- I'm a worthy member of the FL class
- I've learnt interesting things
- In class, I feel proud of my accomplishments
- It's a positive environment
- It's cool to know a FL
- It's fun
- Making errors is part of the learning process
- The peers are nice
- The teacher is encouraging
- The teacher is friendly
- The teacher is supportive
- There is a good atmosphere
- We form a tight group
- We have common 'legends', such as running jokes
- We laugh a lot

The FLCA scale

- Even if I am well prepared for FL class, I feel anxious about it
- I always feel that the other students speak the FL better than I do
- I can feel my heart pounding when I'm going to be called on in FL class
- I don't worry about making mistakes in FL class (reverse-coded)
- I feel confident when I speak in FL class (reverse-coded)
- I get nervous and confused when I am speaking in my FL class
- I start to panic when I have to speak without preparation in FL class
- It embarrasses me to volunteer answers in my FL class

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Notes

(1) Six did not indicate their sex.
(2) The proportions were calculated for the 1044 participants who responded to this question.

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